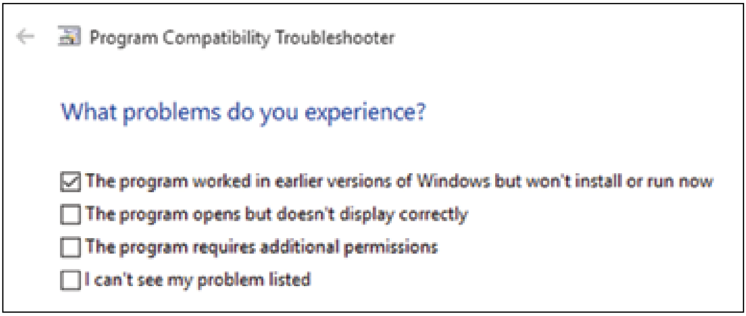

Windows also includes a compatibility troubleshooter that walks you through running an old program on the latest Windows release.

So in Windows 10, compatible applications will get Windows 10 as the version number while older apps will get the version number that they are most comfortable working under. Windows 10 will keep changing over its lifetime and as such Microsoft has given developers tools to detect what features it supports, rather than guessing that from the version number.

Thanks to the continuous efforts in not breaking compatibility, each version of Windows expands its ecosystem, and Windows 10 actually does this a lot more than previous versions. To make this possible though, Windows has gone through many architectural changes.

Architectural Changes

The earliest versions of Windows were essentially applications running on top of DOS rather than being full operating systems. It was Windows NT 3.1 that first got away from a DOS core and switched to the NT kernel that is still used today. It introduced the Win32 API that still powers most Windows applications.

Unfortunately, when Windows NT 3.1 was originally released it had unusually high system requirements, such as a recommended 16MB of RAM,! Shocking, we know. This among other reasons meant that Windows NT didn't become viable for consumer versions of Windows until the release of Windows XP in 2001. That is when the consumer and workstation / server versions of Windows merged into a single family of operating systems. Another such historic merging came with Windows 8.

While we focused on desktop versions of Windows in the previous chapter, there were other operating systems that Microsoft created. Win-